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# Advancing Partnerships Between Private Sector and Development Actors in Africa

**Translating social-impact opportunities into scalable and investable partnership pathways across Sub-Saharan Africa**

**Toolkit Quick Guide**

**Developed in partnership with:**

FUTURE AFRICA Consulting

FCAfrica

### What problem this toolkit helps solve

Many development and private-sector opportunities are worthwhile but stall between idea and execution. Demand is real but no one is set up to pay; providers exist but are fragmented; capital is available but the opportunity is not prepared for it. Effort and funding then go into the wrong fix.

This toolkit helps a team work out, with evidence, how ready an opportunity is to move forward, what is really blocking it (the binding constraint), and which partnership model, institutional roles, capital and risk arrangements would unblock it. The result is a decision-ready case that a funder, partner or internal committee can act on.

**Who it is for:** teams designing or assessing partnerships, including colleagues and partners who were not involved in developing the toolkit.

**What you end up with:** a scored diagnosis, a confirmed binding constraint, a recommended partnership pathway, a written case, a short design deck, and a recorded decision with owned next actions.

### What this guide is

A short operating guide for using the Excel, Word and PowerPoint components as one process. It explains sequence, handoffs and decision gates. It does not repeat every question contained in the tools. Each step names the file and the exact tab, tool or slide to use, and flags where the Excel workbook does the calculation for you.

| Excel | Word | PowerPoint |
|---|---|---|
| DeployabilityToolkit.xlsx | PartnershipAssessmentWorkbook.docx | DesignWorkbook.pptx |
| **Assess and diagnose** | **Gather evidence and document judgement** | **Synthesize and present the proposed design** |
| ReadMe and Scoring Guide<br>Opportunity Profile<br>Tool 1 Deployability Scorecard<br>Tool 2 Binding Constraints<br>Tool 3 Actor Map<br>Tool 4 System Readiness<br>Tool 5 Partnership Model Selection<br>Tool 6 Role Selection<br>Tool 7 Capital Sequencing<br>Tool 8 Risk Allocation<br>Deployability Dashboard | Tool 1 Political Economy Assessment<br>Tool 2 Stakeholder Interview Guide<br>Tool 3 Partnership Case Narrative<br>Tool 4 Decision and Action Record<br>Tool 5 Learning and Adaptation Review<br>Annex A Key terms<br>Annex B Evidence classification | Slide 2 Master Partnership Design Template<br>Slides 3 to 5: one per partnership model<br>Slide 6 Capital Pathway<br>Slide 7 Risk Allocation<br>Slide 8 Institutional Roles<br>Slide 9 Implementation and Decision |

**Tool numbers restart in each file.** In this guide, "Excel Tool 2" means the Binding Constraints tab and "Word Tool 2" means the Stakeholder Interview Guide. File names carry a date prefix and a version; use the same version across all three files.

### Two ways to use the toolkit

| Path | Use it when | Complete |
|---|---|---|
| **Rapid screen** | You need a first view of whether an opportunity is worth pursuing, or which constraint to investigate. | Excel: Opportunity Profile, Tool 1 Scorecard and Tool 2 Binding Constraints. Word: Tool 1 sections 3, 6 and 10; 4 to 6 targeted interviews with Tool 2; a short Tool 4 decision record. |
| **Full partnership design** | You are preparing a partnership, financing or investment decision. | Every stage in Section 1, in order. |

You do not need to read every row before starting. Each Excel tool explains its scale in row 5 and includes a worked example; the Scoring Guide tab is there for when you are unsure between two scores.

### Key terms

| Term | What it means in this toolkit |
|---|---|
| **Deployability** | How far an opportunity has been turned into a structure that capital, institutions and delivery actors can actually execute. |
| **Political economy** | How power, interests, incentives and relationships, formal and informal, shape who decides, who benefits, and whether a partnership can happen and last. |
| **Binding constraint** | The single blockage that, if removed, would most move the opportunity toward execution. It is not automatically the lowest score. |
| **Bankable demand** | Need that is linked to someone able and committed to pay: a budget, contract, tariff, reimbursement or offtake. |
| **Payer, purchaser or offtaker** | The actor that pays for the service or output, and the mechanism through which it pays. |
| **Triangulation** | Checking a conclusion against at least two different kinds of evidence: documents or data, stakeholder views, and observed practice (Section 4). |
| **Ecosystem orchestrator** | The actor that keeps partners aligned and moving from design through financing and implementation. |
| **RAG rating** | Red, amber or green status that the Excel workbook assigns automatically from average scores. |
| **Catalytic and first-loss capital** | Funding that absorbs early or first losses so that other investors can participate. |
| **Take-out** | Later financing that refinances or buys out earlier capital so that it can be recycled. |

*More terms are defined in the Word workbook, Annex A.*

## 1. The workflow at a glance

| Stage | What happens | Where (file and tool) | Output |
|---|---|---|---|
| **1. Frame** | Define the opportunity and the decision. | Excel: Opportunity Profile | Agreed scope and decision question. |
| **2. Gather** | Collect documents, political economy evidence and stakeholder views. | Word: Tool 1 Political Economy Assessment; Tool 2 Stakeholder Interview Guide | Facts, views, assumptions and gaps. |
| **3. Assess** | Score deployability, constraints, actors and systems. | Excel: Tools 1 to 4 | Readiness and binding-constraint diagnosis. |
| **4. Triangulate** | Compare scores with documents, interviews and actual practice. | Excel evidence columns; Word Tool 2 section 5 (interview synthesis) | Validated or provisional findings. |
| **5. Select** | Choose model, roles, capital sequence and risk allocation. | Excel: Tools 5 to 8 | Recommended pathway and conditions. |
| **6. Synthesize** | Write the case and populate the design slides. | Word: Tool 3 Partnership Case Narrative; PowerPoint: slides 2 to 9 | Decision-ready case and design. |
| **7. Decide** | Approve, set conditions, defer, redesign or stop. | Word: Tool 4 Decision and Action Record | Formal decision and owned actions. |
| **8. Implement and learn** | Deliver through gates, monitor and update. | PowerPoint: slide 9; Word: Tool 5 Learning and Adaptation Review | Implementation evidence and revised design. |

### Who does what

| Role | Minimum responsibility | Main tools |
|---|---|---|
| **Toolkit lead** | Owns scope, sequence, integration and version control. | Opportunity Profile, Dashboard, all three files |
| **Evidence lead** | Maintains sources, interviews, classifications and gaps. | Word Tools 1 and 2; Excel evidence columns |
| **Assessment team** | Scores against evidence and documents rationale. | Excel Tools 1 to 8 |
| **Decision authority** | Makes and records the decision. | Word Tool 4; PowerPoint slide 2 |
| **Implementation owner** | Owns milestones, conditions and reporting. | PowerPoint slide 9; Word Tool 5 |

**Do not start with scoring**

First define the decision and gather enough evidence to make the scores meaningful.

## 2. Frame and gather

### Stage 1: Frame the opportunity

1. Open the Excel workbook at the ReadMe tab, then go to the Opportunity Profile tab. Yellow cells are for you to fill in; blue cells calculate automatically.
2. Enter one clearly bounded opportunity, not an entire sector or broad ambition.
3. Identify geography, stage, users, payer or purchaser, delivery actors, current funding, target scale and the decision the assessment must support.
4. Copy the same opportunity name, geography, owner, date and version to the Word workbook cover.

| Input rule | Good practice |
|---|---|
| **Current stage** | Select the stage demonstrated by completed work, not the intended future stage. |
| **Payer / purchaser** | Name the actor and payment mechanism. If unresolved, write “unresolved.” |
| **Target scale** | Use a measurable volume, geography, user, asset or capital target. |
| **Decision question** | Write a decision that can be answered, such as proceed, redesign, select a model or authorise preparation. |

### Stage 2: Gather and classify evidence

1. Use Word Tool 1 (Political Economy Assessment) to map formal authority, informal influence, incentives, commitment, resistance, legitimacy and ownership. **Political economy** means how power, incentives and relationships shape whether a partnership can happen and last.
2. Use Word Tool 2 (Stakeholder Interview Guide) with relevant government, operator, financier, donor, CSO, intermediary and user perspectives.
3. Classify each important input before it is used in scoring, using the categories below (also in the Word workbook, Annex B).

| Classification | How to treat it |
|---|---|
| **Verified fact** | Use directly and record the source, date and relevant evidence. |
| **Stakeholder view** | Attribute it and compare it with other sources. |
| **Assumption** | Label it and define how and when it will be tested. |
| **Evidence gap** | Do not guess. Assign an owner, method and deadline. |
| **Recommendation** | Keep separate from evidence until the diagnosis is complete. |

**Exit gate**

The opportunity is consistently defined across files, and the evidence is broad enough to cover demand, payment, delivery, authority, finance, legitimacy and systems.

## 3. Assess deployability

### Complete the Excel tools in this order

| Order | Excel tab | How to use the result |
|---|---|---|
| **1** | Tool 1 Deployability Scorecard | Identify strong and weak readiness dimensions. |
| **2** | Tool 2 Binding Constraints | Identify the blockage whose removal would materially unlock progress. |
| **3** | Tool 3 Actor Map | Test mandate, incentive, authority, capacity, legitimacy and risk-bearing ability. |
| **4** | Tool 4 System Readiness | Identify enabling systems that can or cannot support execution. |

The Scorecard gives a quick read across seven dimensions. Tools 2 to 4 go deeper: System Readiness expands Scorecard criteria S1 to S4, and the Actor Map tests the institutions behind criteria I1 to I4. Tools 2, 3, 4, 6, 7 and 8 each include a worked example below the main table, based on one fictional case.

### What the Excel does for you

| Excel tab | Calculates automatically | You still decide |
|---|---|---|
| **Tool 1 Scorecard** | Dimension averages, RAG status, overall score out of 140, overall rating and the weakest scored dimension. | The scores, the evidence, and a priority action for every weak or blank criterion. |
| **Tool 2 Binding Constraints** | Priority score (Severity x Immediacy), primary and secondary constraint, and a suggested model. | Whether the top-ranked constraint passes the binding-constraint test. Confirm or override it in row 22. |
| **Tool 3 Actor Map** | Overall fit for each actor and the strongest actor. | Which actors matter, their scores and the gaps. |
| **Tool 4 System Readiness** | Average and RAG for each system, and the weakest system. | Scores, strengthening actions and owners. |
| **Tool 5 Model Selection** | Average fit for each model and the recommended model. | Whether the result fits the confirmed constraint, and whether a hybrid or sequence is needed. |
| **Tool 6 Role Selection** | Overall fit for each role, the best-fit role and the top three candidate roles. | Who holds each role (column K) and where role boundaries sit. |
| **Tool 7 Capital Sequencing** | The highest-need and most-ready capital types. | Entry conditions, providers and sequence. |
| **Tool 8 Risk Allocation** | Inherent score per risk, the highest risk and average residual risk. | Best-placed owners, treatment and monitoring triggers. |
| **Dashboard** | Pulls all headline results onto one page. | The decision, top three actions, owners and assumptions. |

### Scoring rule

| Score | Meaning |
|---|---|
| **1** | **Critical weakness.** Condition is absent or contradicted by evidence. |

| Score | Meaning |
|---|---|
| **2** | **Significant gaps.** Elements exist but are informal, unreliable or untested. |
| **3** | **Partially developed.** Condition works in a limited setting but is not robust or repeatable. |
| **4** | **Strong.** Condition is operational, evidenced and broadly reliable. |
| **5** | **Fully ready (optimal).** Condition is proven, repeatable and institutionally embedded. A decision-maker would need no further evidence on this point. |

This scale applies to the Scorecard and System Readiness. The other tools use their own scales (Severity and Immediacy, Likelihood and Impact, Need and Readiness, fit scores); each tab shows its key in row 5, and a pop-up appears when you select a score cell. On Binding Constraints and Risk Allocation, 5 means worse. The Scoring Guide tab describes what 1, 3 and 5 look like for every Scorecard criterion.

- Score the present condition, not an intention or planned solution.
- Enter the evidence or rationale beside every score.
- Leave the score blank when evidence is insufficient.
- Record a priority action in the Scorecard's Priority action column for every score of 1 or 2 and every blank. Examples sit below the Scorecard summary.
- If assessors differ by two or more points, record the range and reason in the Evidence column before resolving it.

### Binding-constraint test

The Binding Constraints tab ranks constraints automatically by Severity x Immediacy and shows the top one as the primary binding constraint. Treat that result as a hypothesis, not an answer. Nor is the binding constraint automatically the lowest Scorecard score. Ask: if this issue were resolved, would the opportunity materially move closer to execution? Separate the root cause from symptoms and wider system weaknesses, then confirm or override the result in row 22 of the tab. The Dashboard and the suggested model use the confirmed constraint.

### Exit gate

Every score is traceable to evidence, critical blanks have follow-up actions, and the preliminary binding constraint is supported by more than one tool.

### 4. Triangulate and validate

Triangulation tests whether a material conclusion holds across different evidence lenses. Use at least two, and preferably three, of the following: documents or quantitative records; stakeholder perspectives; and observed institutional or operational practice.

| Result | Meaning | Action |
|---|---|---|
| **Convergent** | Different sources support the same conclusion. | Retain and record confidence. |
| **Partly convergent** | The core finding agrees, but cause, scale or timing differs. | Retain provisionally and state what remains unresolved. |
| **Contradictory** | Credible sources support different conclusions. | Do not average. Investigate definitions, timing, authority and evidence quality. |
| **Single-source** | Only one source supports the conclusion. | Mark low confidence and seek corroboration. |
| **Evidence absent** | There is no reliable basis for judgement. | Leave blank or label as an assumption. |

**Where to record it:** note the result in the Evidence column of the relevant Excel tool (for example, "Convergent: budget statement and three interviews"), and carry any material disagreement into Word Tool 4, section 3.

#### Questions to ask

- Do budgets, contracts or payment records support claims about payer credibility?
- Do user and CSO perspectives support institutional claims about demand and adoption?
- Do operator records support claims about capacity, cost and repeatability?
- Do finance providers agree that the proposed cash flows and risks are financeable?
- Does actual practice match formal approval and procurement pathways?
- Are political economy risks reflected in actor, role and risk assessments?

#### Record disagreement

1. State the exact proposition under dispute.
2. Record each position and its evidence.
3. Check for differences in geography, period or definition.
4. Identify the evidence or authority needed to resolve it.
5. If unresolved, carry it forward as a condition or evidence gap.

#### Exit gate

The binding constraint and other material findings are either validated by converging evidence or clearly marked provisional.

## 5. Select the partnership pathway

### Use the Excel selection tools

| Decision | Excel tab | Core test |
|---|---|---|
| **Partnership model** | Tool 5 Partnership Model Selection | Which model directly addresses the confirmed binding constraint? |
| **Institutional roles** | Tool 6 Role Selection | Which roles can a named institution credibly play, judged on mandate, authority, capability, resources, legitimacy and risk appetite? Copy the tab to assess each institution. |
| **Capital pathway** | Tool 7 Capital Sequencing | What constraint does each instrument address, and what milestone unlocks the next source? |
| **Risk allocation** | Tool 8 Risk Allocation | Who can control, mitigate or absorb each risk, and what remains afterward? |

### Model selection

| Model | Use when |
|---|---|
| **1. Aggregation and Warehouse Platforms** | Fragmented or sub-scale actors, assets, contracts, receivables or cash flows need pooling and standardization. |
| **2. Integrated Project Preparation + Guarantee Platforms** | Visible opportunities are blocked by preparation, approvals, payment security or defined risks. |
| **3. Predictable Delivery Networks** | Providers exist, but purchasing, standards, verification, payment or liquidity are fragmented. |
| **Hybrid or sequence** | More than one constraint must be addressed in a deliberate order. |

### Consistency test

- The model addresses the constraint.
- Essential roles have credible owners.
- Each capital instrument has a stated purpose and entry condition.
- Risk mitigation follows risk allocation.
- Legitimacy, accountability, inclusion and local ownership affect the design.

**Warning**
Do not use guarantees to hide weak demand or poor preparation. Do not assign an aggregator, purchaser or orchestrator role to an institution that cannot perform it.

## 6. Synthesize the partnership case and design

### Step 1: Draft the Partnership Case Narrative (Word Tool 3)

Explain why the proposed pathway follows from the evidence. Complete the executive summary last. State material weaknesses, gaps and conditions openly.

| Narrative section (Word Tool 3) | Pull from |
|---|---|
| **Challenge and opportunity (section 2)** | Excel: Opportunity Profile. Word: Tool 1 sections 2 and 5; Tool 2 interview synthesis. |
| **Demand, payment and delivery (sections 3 and 4)** | Excel: Scorecard (demand, financial and delivery dimensions). Word: Tool 2 interviews and documentary evidence. |
| **Diagnostic conclusion (section 5)** | Excel: Dashboard and Binding Constraints (confirmed constraint, row 22). Triangulation notes (Section 4 of this guide). |
| **Model, roles and governance (sections 6 and 7)** | Excel: Tool 5 Model Selection, Tool 3 Actor Map, Tool 6 Role Selection. Word: Tool 1 sections 3, 4 and 10. |
| **Capital and risk (sections 8 and 9)** | Excel: Tool 7 Capital Sequencing, Tool 8 Risk Allocation. Word: Tool 2 investor, bank and DFI module. |
| **Legitimacy and ownership (section 10)** | Excel: System Readiness SR13 to SR21. Word: Tool 1 section 8; Tool 2 CSO and community modules. |
| **Implementation and decision (sections 11 to 13)** | Word: Tool 4 Decision and Action Record. PowerPoint: slide 9. |

### Step 2: Populate the PowerPoint

- Complete the Master Partnership Design Template (slide 2) with conclusions, not raw evidence.
- Complete only the primary model slide (slide 3, 4 or 5), plus a second model only when the pathway is genuinely hybrid or sequenced.
- Complete the Capital Pathway (slide 6), Risk Allocation (slide 7), Institutional Role (slide 8), and Implementation and Decision (slide 9) slides.
- Hide or delete unused model slides in the opportunity-specific copy.
- Keep detailed evidence in Word or source files, not in the design slides.

### Cross-file check

The Excel Dashboard, the Word Case Narrative (Tool 3) and the PowerPoint must state the **same binding constraint, selected model, principal roles, capital pathway, risks, conditions and decision requested.**

**Exit gate**

A decision-maker can understand what is proposed, why, under which conditions, by whom and with what risks without reading every working file.

## 7. Decide and implement

### Record the decision in Word Tool 4 (Decision and Action Record)

| Status | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Approved | Proceed within the authorised scope and resources. |
| Conditional | Proceed only when named conditions are met and evidenced. |
| Deferred | Wait for evidence, authority or changed conditions. |
| Redesign | Revise the pathway because the proposed design does not resolve the diagnosis. |
| Stopped | Do not proceed under the current opportunity or model. |

1. Record the decision forum, authority, participants and evidence reviewed.
2. Summarize the principal findings and any material disagreement.
3. Record decision status, rationale, conditions and owner.
4. Convert every condition and evidence gap into an action with a deadline and completion evidence.
5. Record escalation and required approvals.

### Build the implementation roadmap in PowerPoint (slide 9)

For 0–90 days, 3–6 months, 6–12 months, 12–24 months and 24+ months, define:

- decision or gate;
- deliverables;
- one accountable owner;
- dependencies and conditions;
- completion evidence; and
- next review date or trigger.

### Implementation rule

A milestone is not complete because an activity occurred. It **is complete when the agreed evidence demonstrates that the condition or deliverable has been satisfied.**

#### Exit gate

The decision is explicit, resources and authority match the approved work, and every immediate action has an owner, deadline and completion evidence.

## 8. Learn, update and control versions

### Use Word Tool 5 (Learning and Adaptation Review)

1. Compare expected and actual performance across demand, payment, delivery, coordination, capital, risk, legitimacy and ownership.
2. Classify critical assumptions as validated, partly validated, disproved or unknown.
3. Record changes in policy, leadership, finance, community context, operations or technology.
4. Decide what should continue, adapt, stop or escalate.
5. Identify which Excel, Word and PowerPoint outputs must change (Tool 5, section 6 lists them).

### When to rescore

- New evidence changes a material readiness criterion.
- A binding constraint is resolved or replaced by another constraint.
- The payer, delivery model, institutional role or capital pathway changes.
- A material risk changes in likelihood, impact, ownership or mitigation.
- The opportunity moves to a new implementation stage.

### Version-control rule

- Preserve the approved prior version.
- Record what changed, why, who approved it and the date.
- Use the same version identifier across all three files.
- Seek a new formal decision when the model, roles, capital, risk, scope or conditions change materially.

### Final quality checklist

☐ Same opportunity scope and version across all files.

☐ Evidence is traceable and assumptions are labelled.

☐ Scores match the evidence.

☐ Binding constraint is validated, not merely the lowest score.

☐ Model, roles, capital and risks are mutually consistent.

☐ Word and PowerPoint present the same recommendation.

☐ Decision, conditions, owners and deadlines are explicit.

☐ Next review date or trigger is recorded.

**Use with:**

- DeployabilityToolkit
- PartnershipAssessmentWorkbook
- DesignWorkbook

## 9. Quick reference: where information moves

| From | Information handed forward | To |
|---|---|---|
| **Excel: Opportunity Profile** | Scope, users, payer, actors and decision | Word: Tools 1 and 2 |
| **Word: Tools 1 and 2** | Facts, views, assumptions and gaps | Excel: Tools 1 to 8 |
| **Excel: Tool 1 Scorecard** | Readiness strengths and weaknesses | Excel: Tool 2; Word: Tool 3 |
| **Excel: Tool 2 Binding Constraints** | Confirmed primary and secondary constraints | Excel: Tool 5 Model Selection |
| **Excel: Tool 3 Actor Map; Word: Tool 1** | Authority, incentives, capability and legitimacy | Excel: Tool 6 Role Selection; governance design |
| **Excel: Tool 4 System Readiness** | Foundational weaknesses and actions | Model conditions and implementation plan |
| **Excel: Tools 5 to 8** | Recommended pathway and conditions | Word: Tool 3; PowerPoint |
| **Word: Tool 3; PowerPoint** | Decision-ready case and design | Decision forum |
| **Word: Tool 4** | Approval, conditions and actions | PowerPoint: slide 9 roadmap |
| **Word: Tool 5** | New evidence and adaptations | Updated Excel, Word and PowerPoint versions |

### Minimum viable use

For a rapid screen, complete the Excel Opportunity Profile, Tool 1 Scorecard and Tool 2 Binding Constraints; 4 to 6 targeted interviews with Word Tool 2; Word Tool 1 sections 3, 6 and 10; and a short decision record in Word Tool 4. For full partnership design, complete the entire sequence.

### The operating principle

**Evidence → diagnosis → design → decision → implementation → learning**
Do not reverse the sequence. Capital instruments, partnership models and institutional roles should emerge from the validated constraint and evidence, not precede them.